# AFTER SHAVE

It might be all the rage in the Indian cricket team, but in politics a beard still carries the old sense of renunciation or penance. That's exactly the spirit in which Uttam Kumar Reddy, who was made Telangana Congress chief in the run-up to the 2018 assembly poll, declared after that resounding loss that he would not shave till the Grand Old Party reclaimed India's youngest state. So all these years, with the Congress showing no signs of being out of the woods, he let the foliage grow on his face—almost symbolising a certain defeatism. The occasional trim wasn't enough to dilute those connotations. But he stayed true to his vow, unfazed even when the TRS/ BRS likened him to a grizzly bear. Now, with the razor-sharp Revanth Reddy at the helm, pollsters are predicting a close shave for the ruling party. With barely a week of campaigning left, Uttam Reddy was waxing confident about a clean look being imminent. So confident that he now vows to take sanyas in case of a loss. ■



*Illustrations by*
**SIDDHANT JUMDE**

# THE POSTMAN RINGS THRICE



## Clearance Sale

Indian gods can be moody. And their worshippers must cope with the fluctuating benevolence. But Gunda Ravinder has had enough of it, and is contemplating apostasy. His deity? None other than Bharat Rashtra Samithi supremo K. Chandrashekar Rao. A staunch statehood campaigner, Gunda had struck a personal rapport with KCR during the "struggle and sacrifice" days. So taken was he that, in 2016, he built a temple in front of his home at Dandepalli, Adilabad district, installed a KCR idol, and began praying for his deity's good health and the welfare of Telangana. But, but...his attempts to meet God in real life always went in vain. He's disillusioned enough to now want to sell off the temple. And why not? He doesn't get support "even to maintain the temple", on which he spent Rs 2 lakh. He's not even looking for profits. Someone covering the cost price would do. ■